A Maltese tale tells of a poor widow, who had only home-grown vegetables, a few eggs from her chickens, and a little soft, local cheese. She made this simple, but delicious soup.

widow's soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 7 MINS **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

1 tbsp olive oil
1 large onion, chopped
1 large potato, chopped
6oz (175g) cauliflower florets, quartered
6oz (175g) carrots, sliced
1 small lettuce head, shredded
6oz (175g) shelled fresh peas or thawed frozen peas
9oz (250g) tomatoes, peeled and coarsely chopped, or half a 14oz (400g) can chopped tomatoes
1½ tbsp tomato purée
1 tsp sugar
1 tsp red wine vinegar
salt and freshly ground black pepper
6 eggs
9oz (250g) ricotta cheese or firm young goat cheese

1 Heat the oil in a large pan and cook the onion until soft, but not colored. Add the potato, cauliflower, carrots, lettuce, and fresh peas, if using. Stir, then add the tomatoes, tomato purée, sugar, vinegar, salt and pepper, and enough water (or stock) to cover generously. Bring to a boil and simmer until the vegetables are almost tender. If using thawed frozen peas, add them now. Taste and adjust the seasoning.

2 Reduce the heat so that the surface of the water is barely simmering. Break the eggs one at a time onto a saucer or ramekin, and slide them into the soup. Poach the eggs until the white has just set, about 8–10 minutes.

3 Cut the cheese into 4–6 portions, according to the number of serving bowls, and place one in each bowl. Carefully place one egg in each bowl, and ladle the soup around the eggs and cheese before serving.